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ARTICLE

One Of The Worst Blood Libels Ever To Appear In The Modern Press



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BY PNW STAFF MAY 15, 2026

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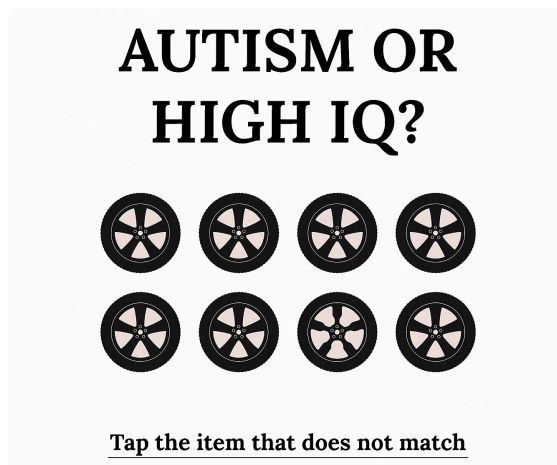
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There are moments when journalism stops being journalism and becomes something else entirely. This week, many critics believe The New York Times crossed that line.

In a controversial opinion column by veteran journalist Nicholas Kristof, the paper amplified explosive accusations claiming Israeli soldiers and prison guards engaged in widespread sexual violence against Palestinian detainees — including one allegation so grotesque and bizarre that it sounded ripped from medieval propaganda: that Israeli authorities allegedly trained dogs to rape prisoners.

The accusation immediately ignited outrage across Israel and among media watchdogs, legal experts, and even some critics of Israel who said the piece relied on deeply questionable sourcing and sensationalized claims. Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu called it a “blood libel,” while Israel’s government announced it was considering legal action against both the newspaper and Kristof personally.

But what made the story especially explosive was not merely what the Times published — it was when they published it.



On the very same day the opinion piece appeared, an Israeli commission released one of the most comprehensive investigations yet into Hamas atrocities committed during the October 7 attacks. According to the report, investigators compiled more than 10,000 photographs

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On one side: mountains of physical evidence, videos, photos, eyewitness testimony, forensic analysis, and even footage recorded by the perpetrators themselves.

On the other: an opinion column built heavily around allegations promoted by activist groups and anonymous testimony — including the now infamous “trained rape dogs” claim, which critics say lacked credible evidence and originated from sources accused of ties to Hamas-linked advocacy networks.

Even some Palestinian voices critical of Hamas questioned the sourcing behind the article. Critics argued the Times appeared eager to create moral equivalence between Hamas terrorists and Israeli soldiers despite the enormous gap in evidence supporting the competing claims.

That distinction matters.



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Because allegations of sexual violence are among the most serious accusations imaginable. They deserve investigation, scrutiny, and truth — not political narrative-building.

If credible crimes were committed by individual Israeli soldiers or prison guards, they should absolutely be investigated and prosecuted. Israel itself has repeatedly stated that accusations backed by evidence should be examined through legal channels. But critics say the Times went far beyond reporting allegations. They argue the paper framed Israel as running a systematic campaign of sexual abuse while relying on claims that remain heavily disputed and in some cases highly implausible.

And many Americans immediately recognized something unsettling in the pattern.

When Hamas atrocities were first reported after October 7, major media outlets — including the Times — were often slow, cautious, and hesitant in acknowledging evidence of sexual violence against Israeli women. Some commentators demanded impossible levels of proof even as videos circulated online and survivors gave testimony.

Yet when accusations targeted Israel, critics say skepticism suddenly vanished.

That double standard is exactly why this controversy has become so explosive.

The issue is not whether Israel is above criticism. No democracy is. The issue is whether one of the world’s most influential newspapers abandoned basic journalistic standards in pursuit of a political narrative.



Media watchdog groups and analysts who examined the column say many readers were never told crucial details about the organizations and activists behind some of the allegations. Others noted that certain testimonies appeared to evolve over time, growing more graphic and sensational in later retellings. Former Israeli Prime Minister Ehud Olmert even publicly stated that the article misleadingly framed his comments as support for claims he never validated.

The damage from stories like this extends far beyond one news cycle.

Historically, accusations of sexual depravity have often been weaponized against Jews during periods of rising hatred and unrest. That is why Israeli officials used the phrase "blood libel" so forcefully. To many Israelis, the article did not read like fair scrutiny. It felt like the resurrection of an ancient tactic: portraying Jews as uniquely monstrous in ways designed to inflame global outrage.

Meanwhile, the documented crimes of Hamas — supported by videos, photographs, forensic reports, eyewitnesses, and even recordings from the attackers themselves — continue to receive less sustained global attention than disputed allegations published in a Western newspaper opinion section.

That reality alone should concern anyone who still believes journalism's first obligation is truth rather than activism.

Because once major institutions begin treating accusation as evidence and narrative as fact, public trust collapses. And when trust collapses, the truth itself becomes the casualty.

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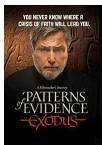
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